to improve relations.[284] Officials were aware of China's concerns about the India-Soviet relationship. Preparing Gandhi for an interview with ABC, Haksar included a message of reassurance for Beijing—and a dig at Washington—in her talking points: that Delhi at least was not intent on "setting China against the Soviet Union and vice versa" since that would be "very short-sighted."[285] In July, Gandhi publicly hoped for China and India to get back to the "slow improvement" in Sino-Indian relations that had stalled during the Bangladesh crisis.[286] Then, in an autumn *Foreign Affairs* article, she explicitly stated, "We want better relations with China."[287]

The goal of reducing its reliance on external partners also likely reinforced Gandhi's decision for India to take a key step on the path to developing nuclear weapons. Just after the 1971 war, intelligence reports had set off a debate in the US about the possibility of an Indian nuclear test. A Defense Department official had fretted that India might find it advantageous to "go … nuclear before the President's trip to Peking."[288] The American embassy in Delhi had said a test was not imminent, but the government might conduct one in the future to demonstrate to domestic hawks its capability to "match" China.[289] State Department intelligence analysts had asserted that the risks outweighed the benefits for India, which would likely defer any decision to go nuclear for "several years."[290] But Rostow wrote to Kissinger predicting that one of the results of Sino-US rapprochement would be deeper Indian exploration of the nuclear option.[291] In July, the president asked the NSC staff to explore the issue.[292]

During the course of that examination, the embassy in Delhi noted, "There is no evidence GOI has decided to stage [a] peaceful test blast."[293] State Department officials concluded that they "didn't know" whether India would conduct a test.[294] Intelligence analysis suggested, "The chances are roughly even that India will conduct a test in the next several years and label it a peaceful explosion."[295] The NSC study recommended that Washington discuss the question with Moscow and keep Beijing informed. It concluded, however, that there was "no firm intelligence that Mrs. Gandhi has given a political go-ahead for detonating an underground nuclear device (which the Indians would undoubtedly label a peaceful nuclear explosion) or for developing nuclear weapons and a delivery system."[296]